

Lesson 04:

Seemingly Unrelated Ayat: ‘Abasa and At-Talaq

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At first glance, the arrangement of the Quran may seem haphazard, but closer analysis shows that all this is part of Allah's wisdom. We may think it is disconnected, but Allah teaches us the connections within it.

كَمَا أَرْسَلْنَا فِيكُمْ رَسُولًا مِّنكُمْ يَتْلُو عَلَيْكُمْ آيَاتِنَا وَيُزَكِّيكُمْ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ الْكِتَابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُم مَّا لَمْ تَكُونُوا تَعْلَمُونَ

— *Just as We have sent among you a messenger from yourselves reciting to you Our verses and purifying you and teaching you the Book and wisdom and teaching you that which you did not know*. Part of this includes – what you think is unconnected, only Allah can teach its connection. (Al-Baqarah: 151)

Evidence of Connection Between Ayat

- In Al-Fatihah, ayat 2-4 are three ayat, but grammatically they are one sentence.
﴿٤﴾ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ ﴿٣﴾ الرَّحْمَنُ الرَّحِيمُ ﴿٢﴾ مَالِكِ يَوْمِ الدِّينِ ﴿١﴾ (1:2-4) – [All] praise and thanks is [due] to Allah, Master of the worlds - **(2)** The Abundantly Merciful, the Ever-Merciful, **(3)** The Owner of the Day of Recompense.
- Ar-Rahman, ayah 1-2. Two ayat, but grammatically one sentence.
﴿٢﴾ عَلَّمَ الْقُرْآنَ ﴿١﴾ الرَّحْمَنُ (55:1-2) – The Most Merciful **(1)** Taught the Quran.
- Al-Ma'un, ayat 4-6. Imagine if ayah 4 is read by itself...
﴿٤﴾ الَّذِينَ هُمْ عَنْ صَلَاتِهِمْ سَاهُونَ ﴿٥﴾ الَّذِينَ هُمْ يُزَاهَوْنَ ﴿٦﴾ (107:4-6) – So the worst destruction shall fall on those who pray **(4)** [But] who are heedless of their prayer - **(5)** Those who make show [of their deeds] **(6)**

These examples show that an ayah cannot be taken in isolation. There is interconnectivity between ayat. However, while the flow may sometimes be obvious, at other times it requires contemplation.

There is also an opinion (Mustansir Mir) quoting the Quran as evidence for the interconnectivity between ayat:

﴿٩٠﴾ – *Just as We had revealed [scriptures] to the separators* (15:90) كَمَا أُنزِلْنَا عَلَى الْمُفْتَسِمِينَ ﴿٩٠﴾

The argument stems from scholars' interpretation as to who الْمُفْتَسِمِينَ may be referring to.

- From the same root word, we get قَسَم – an oath. Some say that these are the people who took an oath to never accept Islam, or an oath to hold on to their false religion and never let go.
- قسم – portion. Others say that these are the people who took portions of the Quran to apply (they accept only parts of the message and disregard others). This seems consistent with the next ayah: ﴿٩١﴾ الَّذِينَ جَعَلُوا الْقُرْآنَ عِضِينَ ﴿٩١﴾ – *Those who made the Quran into portions.*
- Mustansir Mir took this ayah as referring to those who broke the Quran up. Ustadh Nouman is not fully comfortable with this stance because of the context of what the ayah was originally referring to.

Seemingly Unrelated Ayat: Surah 'Abasa

Description: Surah 'Abasa begins with a description of the blind man and the leader of Quraysh, followed by a description of food and provision, then a scene from the Day of Judgment. Some argue the middle portion is disconnected from the rest of the passage, but this apparent disconnection actually brings a profound lesson to those who reflect.

2.1. Case Study #1: Abasa (24-32)

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ
 عَبَسَ وَتَوَلَّى ﴿١﴾ أَنْ جَاءَهُ الْأَعْمَى ﴿٢﴾ وَمَا يُدْرِيكَ لَعَلَّهُ يَزَّكَّى ﴿٣﴾ أَوْ يَذَّكَّرُ فَتَنْفَعَهُ الذِّكْرَى ﴿٤﴾ أَمَّا مَنِ اسْتَغْنَى ﴿٥﴾
 فَأَنْتَ لَهُ تَصَدَّى ﴿٦﴾ وَمَا عَلَيْكَ أَلَّا يَزَّكَّى ﴿٧﴾ وَأَمَّا مَنِ جَاءَكَ يَتَشَكَّى ﴿٨﴾ وَهُوَ يَخْشَى ﴿٩﴾ فَأَنْتَ عَنْهُ تَلَهَّى ﴿١٠﴾ كَلَّا إِنَّهَا
 تَذِكْرَةٌ ﴿١١﴾ فَمَنْ شَاءَ ذَكَرْهُ ﴿١٢﴾ فِي صُحُفٍ مُكَرَّمَةٍ ﴿١٣﴾ مَرْفُوعَةٍ مُطَهَّرَةٍ ﴿١٤﴾ بِأَيْدِي سَفَرَةٍ ﴿١٥﴾ كِرَامٍ بَرَرَةٍ ﴿١٦﴾
 فَتِلْكَ الْإِنْسَانُ مَا أَكْفَرَهُ ﴿١٧﴾ مِنْ أَيِّ شَيْءٍ خَلَقَهُ ﴿١٨﴾ مِنْ نُطْفَةٍ خَلَقَهُ فَقَدَرَهُ ﴿١٩﴾ ثُمَّ السَّبِيلَ يَسْرَهُ ﴿٢٠﴾ ثُمَّ أَمَاتَهُ
 فَأَقْبَرَهُ ﴿٢١﴾ ثُمَّ إِذَا شَاءَ أَنشَرَهُ ﴿٢٢﴾ كَلَّا لَمَّا يَقْضِ مَا أَمَرَهُ ﴿٢٣﴾ فَلْيَنْظُرِ الْإِنْسَانُ إِلَى طَعَامِهِ ﴿٢٤﴾ أَنَّا صَبَبْنَا الْمَاءَ صَبًّا
 ﴿٢٥﴾ ثُمَّ شَقَقْنَا الْأَرْضَ شَقًّا ﴿٢٦﴾ فَأَنْبَتْنَا فِيهَا حَبًّا ﴿٢٧﴾ وَعَيْنَبًا وَقَاصًّا ﴿٢٨﴾ وَرَبَّيْنَاهُا وَنَحْلًا ﴿٢٩﴾ وَحَدَائِقَ غُلْبًا ﴿٣٠﴾
 وَفَاكِهَةً وَأَبًّا ﴿٣١﴾ مَتَاعًا لَكُمْ وَلِأَنْعَامِكُمْ ﴿٣٢﴾ فَإِذَا جَاءَتِ الصَّاحَةُ ﴿٣٣﴾ يَوْمَ يَفِرُّ الْمَرْءُ مِنْ أَخِيهِ ﴿٣٤﴾ وَأُمِّهِ وَأَبِيهِ ﴿٣٥﴾
 وَصَاحِبَتِهِ وَبَنِيهِ ﴿٣٦﴾ لِكُلِّ امْرِئٍ مِنْهُمْ يَوْمَئِذٍ شَأْنٌ يُغْنِيهِ ﴿٣٧﴾ وَجُوهٌ يَوْمَئِذٍ مُسْفَرَةٌ ﴿٣٨﴾ صَاحِكَةٌ مُسْتَبْشِرَةٌ ﴿٣٩﴾
 وَجُوهٌ يَوْمَئِذٍ غَافِرَةٌ ﴿٤٠﴾ تَرَهَقَهَا فَتْرَةٌ ﴿٤١﴾ أُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْكَافِرَةُ الْفَجَرَةُ ﴿٤٢﴾

Translation

1. He frowned and turned away
2. That the blind man came to him, [interrupting].
3. But what would make you perceive, [O Muhammad], that perhaps he might be purified
4. Or be reminded, thus the remembrance would benefit him?
5. As for he who thinks himself is free of need,
6. Towards him you are inclined.
7. And it is not your responsibility if he does not become purified.

8. But as for he who came to you running
9. While he fears [Allah],
10. From him you are distracted.
11. No! Indeed, these verses are a reminder;
12. So whoever wills may remember it
13. [A reminder whose origin is] in dignified scriptures,
14. Exalted and purified,
15. [Carried] by the hands of noble angels,
16. Dignified and righteous.
17. May the man be killed! How ungrateful is he.
18. From what did He create him?
19. From a dirty fluid [i.e. a sperm-drop] He created him and put him into stages;
20. Then He eased the way for him;
21. Then He [for sure will] give him death and [will] put him in his grave.
22. Then when He wills, He will resurrect him.
23. No! [The man] has not yet fulfilled what He commanded him.
24. Then let mankind look at his food –
25. How We poured down water profusely,
26. Then We broke open the earth, splitting [it with sprouts],
27. And caused to grow within it grain
28. And grapes and herbage
29. And olive and palm trees
30. And gardens of dense shrubbery
31. And fruit and grass –
32. [As] enjoyment for you and your grazing livestock.
33. But when the Great Cry comes
34. On the Day a man will flee from his brother
35. And his mother and his father
36. And his wife and his children,
37. For every man, that Day, will be a matter adequate for him [i.e. he will feel free of need from all matters].
38. [Some] faces, that Day, will be bright –
39. Laughing, rejoicing at good news.
40. And [other] faces, that Day, will have upon them dust.
41. Blackness will cover them.
42. Those are the disbelievers, the wicked ones.

Connection

- This surah can be divided into 3 parts:
 - *Ayat 1-23*: Allah addresses Prophet Muhammad's (PBUH) facial change when a blind man (Abdullah ibn Umm Maktum) interrupted his meeting with the leaders of Quraysh. The passage continues with a criticism of the elite who Allah

humbled by saying, “How ungrateful is he!” (ayah 17), then He reminded him of his origin.

- *Ayat 24-32*: There is an apparent switch on the subject, talking about food and provision.
- *Ayat 33-42*: A continuation of what is talked about in ayat 1-23.

Argument:

Surah ‘Abasa seems to flow smoothly without the middle part.

- So what is the food discussion doing there? It is not obvious. Some orientalists (e.g. Montgomery Watt) even argue that this disconnect is a mistake in the surah. *Is it?*
- In ayah 17, Allah highlights the elite’s ingratitude. From here stem two arguments: his origin and his food.
 - When you are told to contemplate on your food, you are told to be grateful.
 - If you cannot contemplate on your own origin, then contemplate on the origin of your food.
- The following connection can be drawn between man and food:
 - Just as food is created from drops of water that enliven the earth (ayah 25), man is also created from a drop of fluid (ayah 19).
 - Just as food comes from the belly of the earth, man also comes from the belly of a mother.
 - Just as Allah opens up the earth for plants to sprout out (ayah 26), He also opens up the way for a baby to come out (ayah 20).
 - Just as Allah causes plants to mature into stages (ayah 27), He also put man into stages (ayah 19).
 - Just as the food we consume will go back to earth, man will also be put into his grave (ayah 21).
 - Just as the food will one day sprout again, man will also one day be resurrected (ayah 22).
- Appropriately, the subsequent passage (ayah 33-42) then describes a scene on the Day of Judgement.

Concluding remarks: We may not have looked at food and thought of resurrection before, but now we do! This is an example of Allah teaching us what we are incapable of ourselves.

“(2:151) *وَيُعَلِّمُكُم مَّا لَمْ تَكُونُوا تَعْلَمُونَ*” – *And He teaches you that which you used to not know.*

Seemingly Unrelated Ayat: Surah At-Talaq

Surah At-Talaq (7-12)

Translation

4. And those who no longer expect menstruation among your women - if you doubt, then their period is three months, and [also for] those who have not menstruated. And for those who are pregnant, their term is until they give birth. And whoever fears Allah - He will make for him of his matter ease.
5. That is the command of Allah, which He has sent down to you; and whoever fears Allah - He will remove for him his misdeeds and make great for him his reward.
6. Lodge them [in a section] of where you dwell out of your means and do not harm them in order to oppress them. And if they should be pregnant, then spend on them until they give birth. And if they breastfeed for you, then give them their payment and confer among yourselves in the acceptable way; but if you are in discord, then there may breastfeed for the father another woman.
7. Let a man of wealth spend from his wealth, and he whose provision is restricted - let him spend from what Allah has given him. Allah does not charge a soul except [according to] what He has given it. Allah will bring about, after hardship, ease.
8. And how many towns has there been that violated the commands of their Master and His messengers, so We took them into severe account and We punished them with a terrible punishment.
9. So they tasted the bad consequence of their affair, and the outcome of their affair was loss.
10. Allah has prepared for them an intense punishment; so have consciousness of Allah, O you with sound minds who believed. Allah has sent down a reminder especially to you.
11. [That came by way of] a Messenger [Muhammad] who recites to you the verses of Allah, clarifying [them] that He may bring out those who believe and do righteous deeds from darkness into light. And whoever believes in Allah and does righteousness - He will admit him into gardens beneath which rivers flow to abide in it forever. Allah will have perfected for him a provision.
12. It is Allah who has created seven skies and of the earth, the like of them. [His] command descends among them so that you may know Allah is in complete control [and capable] over all things and that Allah has encircled all things in knowledge.

Connection

- The only discussion in ayat 1-7 is about divorce, including the divorce of women who are no longer expecting their cycles and the divorce of pregnant women.
- From ayah 8 onwards, the discussion shifts to the destruction of towns, a topic that seems completely unrelated to divorce.
- So what is the connection?
 - The most sacred of relationships is the first relationship Allah created i.e. marriage. This is the fundamental relationship on the basis of which Allah created humanity. It is also the foundation of societies and civilizations.
 - Allah is teaching that when the most personal of relationships is not being regarded as sacred (in the way we come to it and get out of it), then these nations are on the path of destruction. This is how seriously matters of divorce should be taken.

- In other parts of the Quran, we typically see kufr, shirk, and disregarding the prophets as the cause to a nation's destruction, but here, Allah is drawing a connection between such acts to the personal acts of not giving mahr, being unjust to pregnant women and the children affected etc. (i.e. the wrongdoings of divorcing).
- In ayah 11, قَدْ أَحْسَنَ اللَّهُ لَهُ رِزْقًا Allah gives hope to the people who think they are losing rizq, because He will provide other rizq – which may refer not only to monetary provisions, but also relationships and support. This mention of rizq is significant because people who are divorced are dividing their rizq.
- By the end of Surah At-Talaq, the seven skies and the earth are mentioned. This may be a reassurance for the divorcees that the decision of them coming together and parting ways is part of the decree from the seventh heaven – so that they will know that Allah puts a limit on all things (qadr – لَتَعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ), and that nothing lasts forever.

Concluding Remarks

- This set of ayat (ayah 8 onwards) can stand by its own but would not give the same impact if put in another surah.
- In making this connection between the beginning half and latter half of the surah, these ayat give a new shade of meaning to bringing people out of darkness into light, and a new meaning to “Allah has given rizq to everyone.”
- We are reminded of Dr. Hamiduddin Al-Farahi's concept of mahaasin and manaafi' – beauty and benefits. There is a particular benefit when someone experiencing divorce would read this surah (Allah puts a warning, then hope by the end). People going through crisis do not just need to know what is halal and haram, but also need hope and reassurance to get through their difficulty.